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Cohesion and Collapse: Sophocles Against Freud

At the opening of *Oedipus Rex*, Thebes is already dying. The priest stands before Oedipus and describes his city in total collapse: "*A blight on the fresh crops and the rich pastures, cattle sicken and die, and the women die in labor, children stillborn*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus* 31). The city has not been invaded. No army stands at its gates. The destruction comes from within. The priest appeals to Oedipus as the man who once saved the city from the Sphinx, begging him to "*raise up our city, set us on our feet*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 63). However, the terrible irony is already present in that request: the man being asked to save the city is the city's demise. This opening image—civilization rotting from its own center—is what separates Sophocles from Sigmund Freud. In *Totem and Taboo*, Freud argues that the forces most dangerous to civilization—guilt, taboo, and the authority of the dead—are precisely what make civilization possible. Violence becomes guilt, guilt becomes prohibition, and prohibition becomes the foundation of social order. Sophocles stages this same argument across two plays and arrives at the opposite conclusion. In *Oedipus Rex* and *Antigone*, guilt does not find order—it contaminates it. Taboo does not evolve into law—it destroys it. The dead do not stabilize the living—they overwhelm everyone. Freud argues that guilt, taboo, and the authority of the dead are the origins of civilization. However, when read against *Oedipus Rex* and *Antigone*, these same forces emerge not as civilization's foundation but as its

undoing—suggesting that what Freud mistakes for cohesion is, for Sophocles, was always already collapsing.

Freud's account of civilization begins with a paradox: society is born not from innocence but from crime. In *Totem and Taboo*, Freud reconstructs the mythic origin of human social life through the figure of the primal horde—a group of sons living under a violent, jealous father who monopolizes power and women. The sons eventually rebel. They kill him. But the murder does not liberate them. Instead, it destroys them from within, because the same ambition that drove them to kill—hatred intertwined with love and admiration—now produces something Freud identifies as the founding emotion of civilization itself, guilt. Freud states, "*Society was now based on complicity in the common crime; religion was based on the sense of guilt and the remorse attaching to it*" (Freud 170). Freud is not saying guilt is a byproduct of civilization. He is saying guilt is civilization—its foundation and the invisible bond holding the social order together. The sons did not simply mourn their father. Their remorse transformed into prohibition, ritual, and collective conscience. Violence became law and destruction turned into order. For Freud, this transformation is not a tragedy. It is progress in which violence converted into law, destruction into order, crime into conscience. This is the central assumption his entire model of civilization rests on: that guilt when properly channeled, moves toward cohesion. But before that cohesion can take shape, before guilt can become law or institution, it must first pass through something older and more irrational. It must become taboo.

For Freud, guilt is civilization's foundation, but taboo is its first stage. In Part II of *Totem and Taboo*, Freud turns to the structure of taboo itself—its strange, sourceless authority, its irrational yet absolute grip on those who feel it. Taboo, he argues, is not law. It predates law. It has no author, no court, no written code. Yet it commands obedience more completely than

anything because its force is felt inwardly. Freud writes that the violation of a taboo produces guilt in a person who "*cannot fully explain why*" it is forbidden—the prohibition is experienced as an inner law whose origin is obscure but whose force feels absolute (Freud 141). This is crucial because Freud is describing a mechanism by which irrational, pre-rational feeling gradually organizes itself into something resembling rational moral order. Taboo is not the opposite of civilization. It is civilization in its earliest, most naked form. Freud's model moves forward. Taboo becomes law. Guilt becomes an institution. The primitive becomes civilized. It is a story of conversion. That forward movement and the assumption that these forces resolve rather than persist is precisely what Sophocles refuses. Sophocles refuses it most visibly where Freud's model is most confident: in the figure of the dead father, whose authority, Freud promises, will organize rather than destroy the living.

Laius, the father of Oedipus never really appears in *Oedipus Rex*. He is dead before the play begins. And yet he governs everything. The plague devastating Thebes, the oracle commanding investigation, the curse Oedipus pronounces upon the murderer, the catastrophic revelation that ends the play—all of it flows from one unresolved death, one body that was never properly accounted for. Laius is, in this sense, Sophocles' own version of Freud's primal father. His murder generates law, guilt, and the collapse of an entire social order. But where Freud argues that, "*the dead father became stronger than the living one had been*" (Freud 166), his prohibition internalized, his memory honored, his power converted into communal conscience. Laius's authority in *Oedipus Rex* contrasts this because his presence is purely destructive. When Creon returns from Delphi with Apollo's command, he reports that the god demands Thebes "*drive the corruption from the land, / don't harbor it any longer*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 109–110). The language is contamination, not law. Laius does not return as a totem or a moral

anchor. He returns as a plague. His death has not organized Thebes around shared prohibition; it has quietly infected the city from within its own royal house. The dead father, for Sophocles, does not find order. He poisons it. And the man tasked with finding that poison will discover that he has been searching, all along, for himself.

Oedipus does not simply stumble into the truth. He pursues it. With methodical, aggressive rationality, he finds witnesses, cross-examines servants, and builds his case. He became a detective, judge, and prosecutor. Freud's civilized man does not simply feel guilt—he acts on it. The guilt becomes investigation, inquiry, the rational pursuit of accountability. Civilization, for Freud, is what happens when raw emotional force is converted into structured, purposeful action. Oedipus announces his intention explicitly, declaring *"I'll start again — I'll bring it all to light myself!"* (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 150). The phrase is loaded because light here means reason, transparency, civic accountability—everything Freud associates with the successful transition of primitive guilt into rational order. But Sophocles immediately corrupts this idea. The light Oedipus promises to bring reveals not the guilty outsider he expects but the contamination living inside the investigation itself. Every step forward in the inquiry is simultaneously a step deeper into Oedipus's own catastrophe. Freud imagines this investigative impulse as civilization's triumph over its violent origins. Sophocles shows it as the mechanism by which those origins resurface. The harder Oedipus pushes toward the light, the darker everything becomes. But Oedipus is not alone in his relationship to this darkness. Beside him is Jocasta—who has known the darkness far longer, and who has built her entire life on the decision never to look.

Where Oedipus pursues the truth aggressively, Jocasta tries to make it disappear. She represents something Freud's model implicitly depends on but never fully examines—the

possibility of successful repression, of keeping the original crime buried deep enough that civilization can function above it undisturbed. She dismisses the oracles, denies their authority, and urges Oedipus toward a philosophy of radical unknowing: "*Fear? / What should a man fear? It's all chance, / chance rules our lives*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 1068–1070). This is appealing in the worst possible way because if chance rules everything, then nothing can catch up with you, no past crime can reach the present, and there is no reason to look. Jocasta has built her entire life on exactly that logic. She is not simply naive—she has survived decades by not knowing, by constructing a life of queenship and stability on top of an abyss she chose never to look into. The word "*chance*" is precise and devastating because she is not appealing to fate or divine order, she is appealing to randomness itself, to the idea that the universe is too arbitrary to be meaningful, too chaotic to be dangerous. She is the most successfully repressed character in the play—and therefore the most fragile. When the truth finally breaks through, she does not blind herself like Oedipus. She hangs herself. She cannot survive the collapse of the repression that organized her entire existence. This is the uncomfortable truth at the heart of Freud's model, repression does not heal the original wound. It simply covers it. But the burial was never permanent. When the truth finally breaks through, she cannot survive it. Her suicide is not simply a personal tragedy. It is the moment the play closes off its last remaining escape route—the possibility that not knowing might be enough to keep you safe. After Jocasta dies, there is nothing left between Oedipus and the full weight of what he has done.

What makes *Oedipus Rex* so philosophically violent is not the murder or the incest. It is the fact that Oedipus did not know. He killed a stranger on a road, he married a queen that was his mother, and he had no idea. And yet the guilt is catastrophic and inescapable—falling not just on him but on his city, his children, his mother-wife, and his entire world. When the truth finally

reveals itself, Oedipus cries, "O light — now let me look my last on you!" (Sophocles, *Oedipus* 1307–1308), and in the lines that follow after declaring himself cursed in his birth, his marriage, and the lives he took with his own hands. Three curses, three domains—origin, family, action—and none of them chosen. This is where Sophocles most precisely confirms Freud's mechanics while completely reversing his conclusions. Freud notes that in taboo logic, intent is irrelevant—the act itself carries pollution, independent of the actor's knowledge or desire. Oedipus proves this absolutely. But Freud assumes that guilt, even when irrational, eventually does productive work—it civilizes. Oedipus's guilt produces nothing but blindness and exile. No new law emerges from his suffering. No communal bond is forged from his remorse. The city is purified by his expulsion, but Oedipus himself is simply destroyed. Guilt here is not a mechanism of civilization. It is a mechanism of annihilation. If *Oedipus Rex* shows what guilt does to a city organized around a dead king, *Antigone* shows what happens when a living king tries to use a corpse to reorganize the city entirely—and discovers that the dead refuse to be organized.

Polynices is more powerful dead than he ever was alive. In *Antigone*, his unburied corpse becomes the single point every character is forced to respond to—and every response destroys them. King Creon bans his burial to assert the primacy of civic loyalty over kinship. But the prohibition has the opposite effect: it makes the corpse impossible to ignore, transforming a dead traitor into the moral center of the tragedy. Antigone does not hesitate. Facing Creon's decree, she tells her sister Ismene: "*I will bury him myself. / And even if I die in the act, that death will be a glory*" (Sophocles, *Antigone* 84–86). The sentence changes everything. Death becomes glory and burial becomes the highest civic act, more honorable than obedience to the king. The living king holds less authority than the dead brother. Sophocles shows this as uncontainable.

Polynices' corpse does not just threaten Antigone. It kills her, kills Haemon, kills Eurydice, and strips Creon of everything. One unburied body brings down an entire royal house. The dead, in Thebes, cannot be managed. They can only be obeyed. The question Antigone then raises is straightforward and devastating: can any human law survive when it places itself against the obligations the living owe the dead?

Freud's model assumes that taboo and law are sequential—that the primitive, irrational force of taboo gradually evolves into the rational structure of civic order. Antigone destroys this assumption by staging taboo and law not as stages in a progression but as opposites. Creon represents the civic order Freud describes as civilization's achievement: a rational, codified law enforced by the authority of the state. Antigone represents something older and more absolute. When Creon demands she justify her defiance, she appeals to "*the great unwritten, unshakable traditions*" (Sophocles, *Antigone* 504–505). These obligations are so ancient and so deeply felt that they require no author, no text, no enforcement mechanism. They simply are. Antigone is not appealing to a rival legal code. She is appealing to taboo in its purest form, to the kind of prohibition Freud describes as one whose origin is obscure but whose force is absolute. Cosmically, morally, and dramatically, Tiresias confirms the gods have turned against Creon. Haemon, Eurydice, and Antigone all die, but Creon is left alive and utterly ruined. Taboo does not evolve into law in this play. It outlasts it, overwhelms it, and leaves it in ruins. What Freud reads as a primitive precursor, Sophocles treats as a permanent, indestructible force that no civic authority can safely suppress. Both plays make this suppression visible through the same figure—a blind man who arrives when civic authority reaches its absolute limit.

Tiresias appears in both *Oedipus Rex* and *Antigone*, and his presence in each play is structurally similar. He arrives when the city's civic authority has reached the limit of what it can

process, and he says the thing that authority cannot afford to hear. He is blind and yet he sees everything. This is Sophocles' most persistent image of the relationship between human institutions and the forces that exceed them. In *Oedipus Rex*, Tiresias tells Oedipus directly: "*You are the curse, the corruption of the land!*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 400–401). Oedipus responds with fury, accusing him of conspiracy, of madness, and of political manipulation. The word "*curse*" is deliberate and precise—Tiresias does not name Oedipus a criminal in any legal sense. He names him a contamination, something that has leaked into the city's foundations and cannot be removed by ordinary means. In *Antigone*, Tiresias returns with an equally unbearable message for Creon, describing how birds and dogs carrying pieces of Polynices' corpse have fouled the city's altars, "*the public altars and sacred hearths are fouled, / one and all, by the birds and dogs with carrion / torn from the corpse*" (Sophocles, *Antigone* 1124–1126). The image is visceral—the boundary between the sacred and the polluted has collapsed entirely because Creon's law tried to suppress what cannot be suppressed. In both plays, Tiresias embodies Freud's return of the repressed—the truth civic authority buries keeps resurfacing, louder and more destructive each time it is denied. Neither Oedipus nor Creon can silence him. The city cannot silence him. Taboo has its own prophet, and he is always already blind. But if Tiresias is the solitary voice that sees through the city's repression, the chorus is its collective counterpart.

If Tiresias is the voice that civic authority cannot silence, the chorus is the voice of civic authority itself—the collective body of Thebes, the community whose coherence Freud's model promises guilt and taboo will ultimately protect. In *Oedipus Rex*, the chorus begins with confidence, appealing to destiny as the city's core, "*Destiny guide me always / Destiny find me filled with reverence / pure in word and deed*" (Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* 954–956). The appeal is like what Freud argues in structure—the chorus locates authority in something beyond human

origin, something absolute and unwritten, exactly the kind of sacred prohibition Freud identifies as civilization's deepest foundation. The chorus does not appeal to Creon's law or Oedipus's reason. It appeals to destiny—to a force so fundamental it precedes any human institution. But as the investigation proceeds and the truth closes in, the chorus progressively disintegrates. Its confidence becomes anxiety, its appeals become pleas, and by the play's end it can only offer a cold warning: that no man should be counted happy until he is dead. This is not a community bound together by shared guilt in the way Freud describes. This is a community watching its own foundations dissolve in real time, unable to do anything but witness. The chorus does not collectively mourn Oedipus and build a new order from their remorse. They simply lose everything they believed in. Sophocles shows the collective conscience not as civilization's most durable achievement, but as its most fragile one, and the first thing lost. What tears with it, in *Antigone*, is not only collective confidence but individual conscience—and no one bears that rupture more completely than the king who caused it.

If Oedipus shows what guilt does to a man who never intended harm, Creon shows what guilt does to a man who intended everything. The symmetry is devastating. Oedipus broke taboo without knowledge, without desire, without choice—and was destroyed. Creon was more deliberate—he crafted his law carefully, enforced it consciously, ignored every warning—and was destroyed just the same. When the bodies of Haemon and Eurydice are brought before him, Creon does not argue or deflect. He simply declares: *"And the guilt is all mine — / can never be fixed on another man, / no escape for me. I killed you, / I, god help me, I admit it all!"* (Sophocles, *Antigone* 1441–1444). The confession is absolute with no appeal to intention, no defense of civic principle, nothing left of the rational lawgiver who opened the play. And this is precisely what makes the moment so philosophically damning for Freud's model. Freud's guilt is

productive because it is shared—the sons collectively mourn the father, collectively prohibit the crime, collectively build a new order from their remorse. Creon's guilt is solitary, total, and utterly barren. It produces nothing. Thebes has now collapsed twice—once around Oedipus, once around Creon—each time through the same mechanism: guilt spreading through the city's central institution until the institution itself ruptures. This is not Freud's forward moving conversion of violence into order. This is a cycle. Thebes does not learn. It repeats.

Freud's model of civilization is fundamentally generational. The sons kill the father, feel guilt, prohibit themselves from repeating the crime, and pass that prohibition forward—civilization advances precisely because each generation inherits and internalizes the guilt of the one before it. *Antigone* annihilates this logic by killing the next generation entirely. Haemon is Creon's son and Antigone's soon to be wife—he is Thebes' future, its continuity, the living proof that civilization persists beyond the catastrophes of the present. When Creon refuses to release Antigone, Haemon confronts his father with a restraint that makes the scene unbearable: *"you will never / see me, never set eyes on my face again. / Rage your heart out, rage with friends / who can stand the sight of you"* (Sophocles, *Antigone* 856–859). The sentence is quiet and absolute. He does not threaten. He simply withdraws from his father, from the civic order his father represents, from the future Thebes promised him. He goes to the tomb where Antigone has hanged herself and falls on his own sword. Freud never accounts for this. His model requires that guilt be transmitted forward, that the sons survive the father and carry his prohibition into the next generation. But in Sophocles, there are no surviving sons. The generational chain that Freud imagines as civilization's engine is severed completely. What remains is not a new order. It is a king standing alone, surrounded by his dead and stripped of every institution he tried to build, Creon becomes the final image of what both plays have been

arguing from the beginning. The forces Freud reads as civilization's building blocks are, for Sophocles, is the demolition crew.

When read together, *Oedipus Rex* and *Antigone* do not disprove Freud by denying the power of guilt, taboo, or the dead. They confirm that power everywhere and at every turn. Oedipus's guilt is real, Polynices' corpse commands absolute loyalty, and Antigone's taboo outlasts Creon's law. Freud was right about the forces. He was just wrong about what they did. In *Totem and Taboo*, the primal murder sets off a chain reaction that ends in civilization—guilt becomes prohibition, prohibition becomes law, law becomes society. In Sophocles, the same chain reaction ends in rubble. Laius's murder in *Oedipus Rex* becomes plague. Creon's prohibition becomes divine pollution in *Antigone*. Law collides with taboo and both shatter. What Freud reads as a mechanism of cohesion, Sophocles stages relentlessly as a mechanism of collapse. Freud believes that civilization successfully converts its darkest origins into stable order. Sophocles portray this otherwise. Not once but twice, the city of Thebes in *Oedipus Rex* and *Antigone* organizes itself around exactly the forces Freud identifies as civilization's foundation, and not once but twice, those forces consume it entirely. What Freud mistakes for cohesion is, in Sophocles, was always already collapsed. Yet there remains one moment in *Oedipus Rex* that this essay's own argument has not yet fully accounted for—a moment that arrives after the collapse, after the guilt, after the investigation has consumed everything, and asks a question neither Freud nor Sophocles can entirely answer.

There is one moment in *Oedipus Rex* that neither Freud's model nor the play's own logic of guilt and taboo can fully account for. It comes after the revelation, after Jocasta's suicide, after the investigation has consumed everything it set out to protect. Oedipus takes the brooches from Jocasta's robe and drives them into his own eyes. When the chorus asks why, he answers,

"Apollo, friends, Apollo — / he ordained my agonies — these, my pains on pains!" (Sophocles, *Oedipus* 1467), and in the lines that follow insists that the hand that struck his eyes was his alone, no one else's, done entirely by himself. Apollo authored the fate. Oedipus destroyed his own sight. Both things are completely true. What makes this moment so philosophically strange is that it is the only act of genuine free will in the entire play—and Oedipus uses it to blind himself. Throughout *Oedipus Rex*, sight has meant denial. Oedipus could see, and he saw nothing that mattered. He looked at Tiresias and saw a conspirator. He looked at the evidence and saw someone else's crime. He looked at Jocasta and saw a queen. Physical sight, for Sophocles, is the instrument of repression—the way the mind maintains its careful distance from what it cannot afford to know. Tiresias understood this from the beginning. He was blind and he saw everything. Oedipus's self-blinding is therefore not punishment. It is liberation—the violent dismantling of the last defense between himself and the truth. He destroys his sight and finally *sees*. This is what Freud's model cannot account for. Freud's civilization is built on repression, holding on to the original crime staying buried, guilt staying productive, the dead father remaining a stable authority for generations to come. But Sophocles suggests that repression was never meant to hold. It was always temporary, always structural, always building toward the moment it collapses. Thebes cannot repress its way to civilization. The forces it buries are too powerful to stay buried. They return. They always return. And when they do, the only way forward is to gouge out one's own eyes and finally, irreversibly, see. Tiresias was blind his entire life and saw everything. Perhaps that is Sophocles' final argument: that civilization does not begin with what we build, but with what we are finally willing to see.

Work Cited

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